

TRUSTMRR SESSION 3 • DATASET INSIGHTS

What Makes an Early-Stage SaaS Startup Successful?

Insights from 1,000 SaaS startups on TrustMRR.

August 2026

1,000 startups. One question: what actually works?

1,000

SaaS startups tracked on TrustMRR

65

countries represented

29

product categories, from AI to Legal Tech

9

payment providers powering checkout

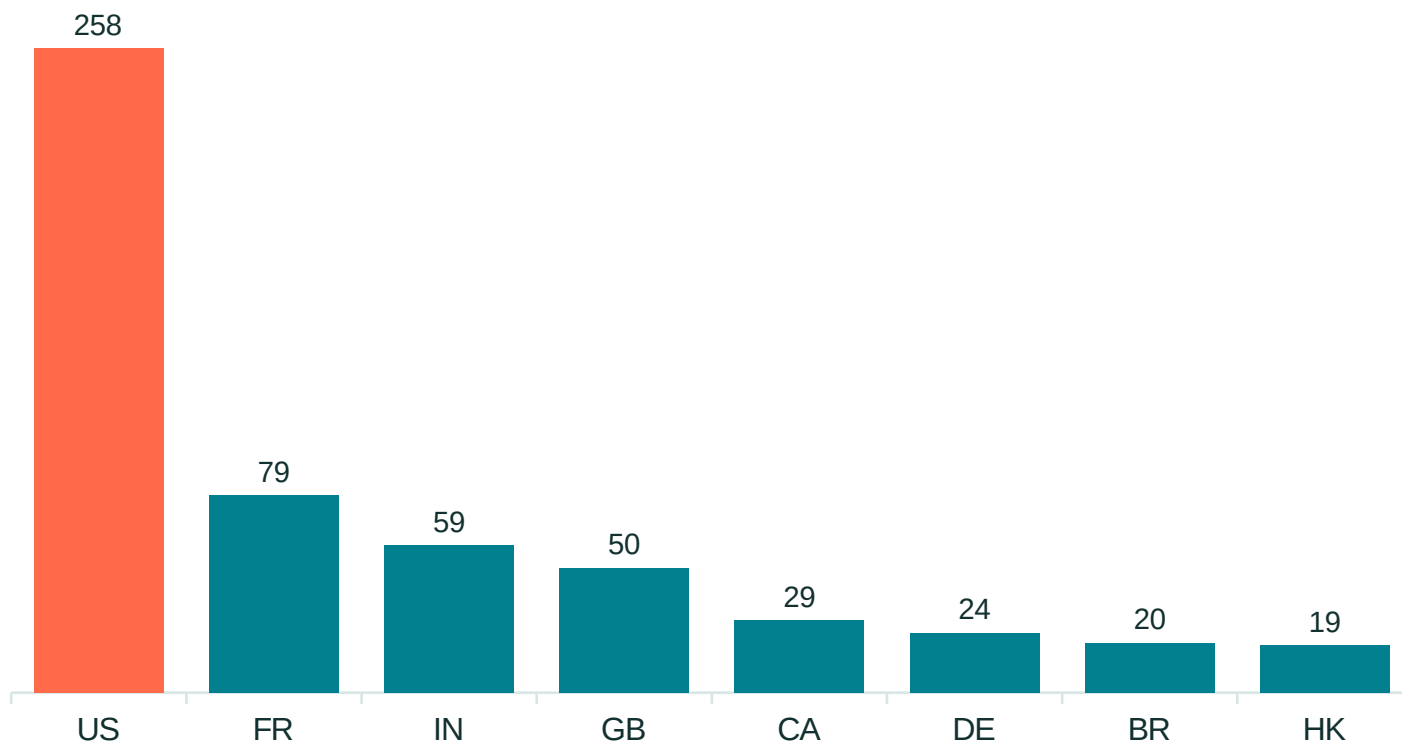
4

revenue windows: 30-day, 3-month, 12-month, all-time

X

founder follower counts + pricing & audience data

Where are startups being built?

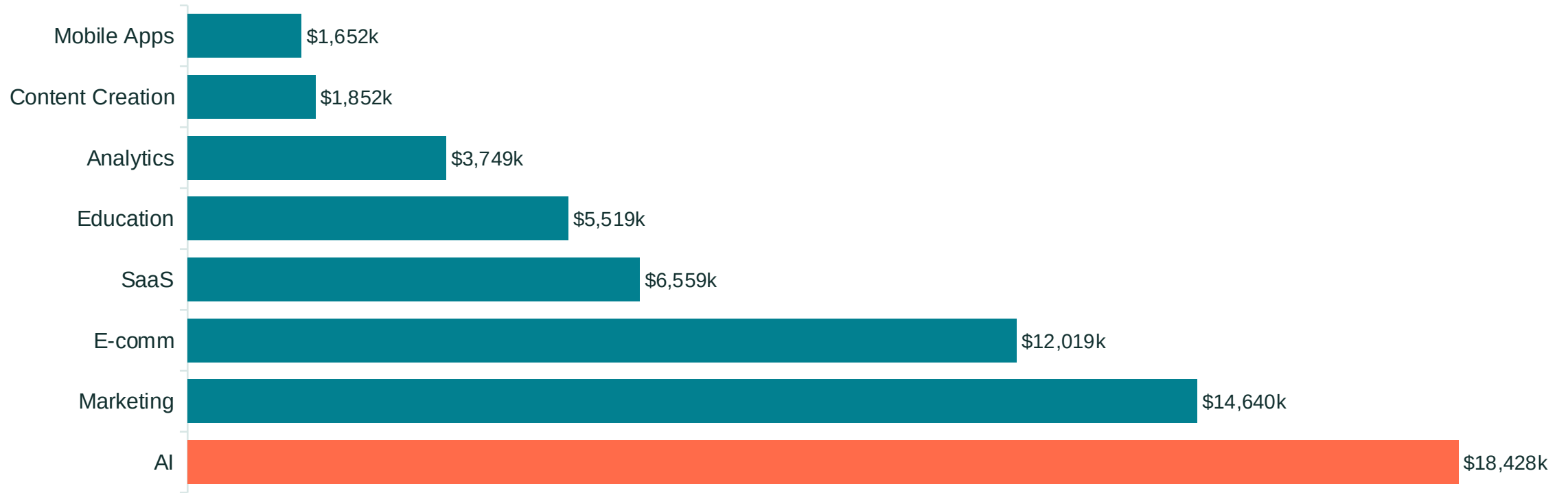


34% of identified startups are US-based — the single largest hub

But the other 66% spans 64 more countries. France, India, the UK and Canada alone add another 28% — SaaS founding is no longer a US-only game.

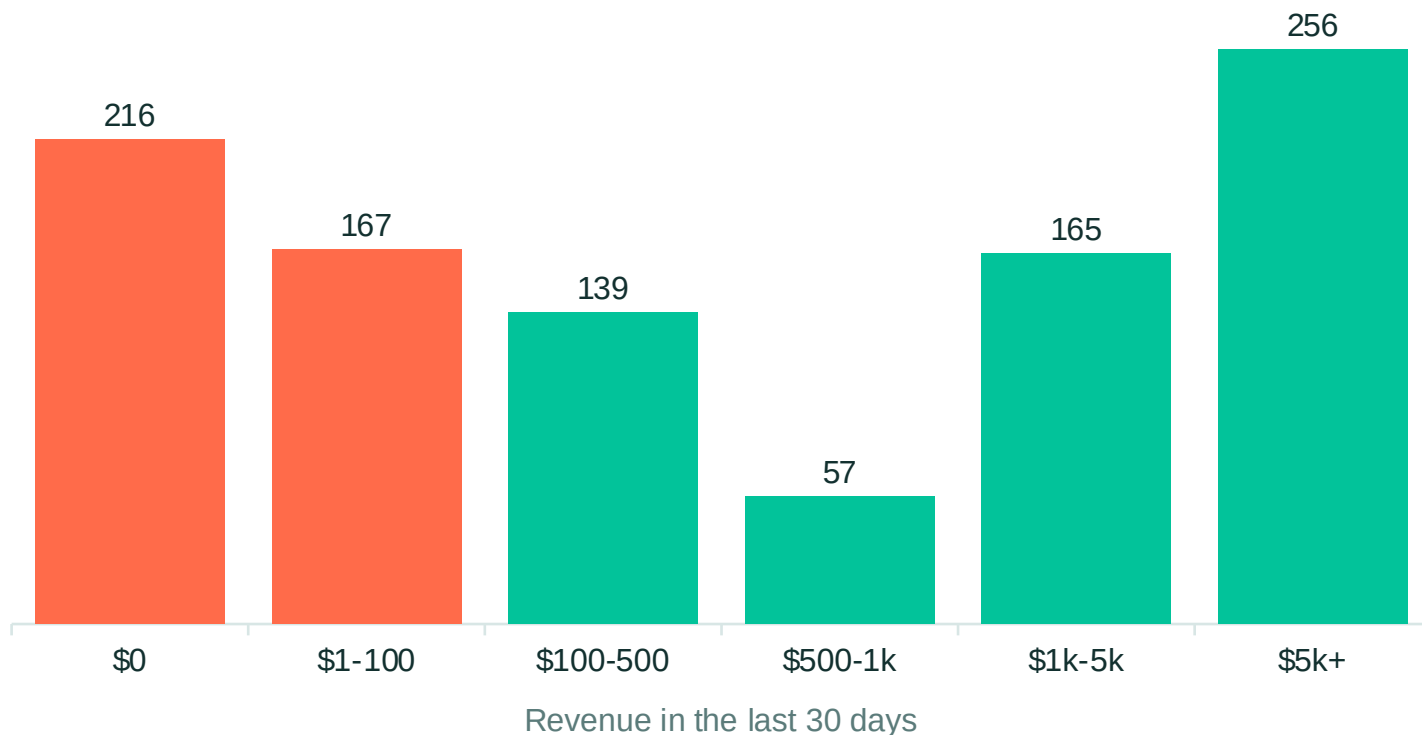
The US still leads startup creation, but India, France and the UK combined already rival it — SaaS entrepreneurship is going global.

Which markets generate the most money?



AI startups pulled in \$18.4M over 12 months — about 3.3x Education's total and more than Marketing and E-comm combined-with-SaaS. Willingness to pay for AI tools is real, not just hype.

Revenue isn't evenly distributed



38%

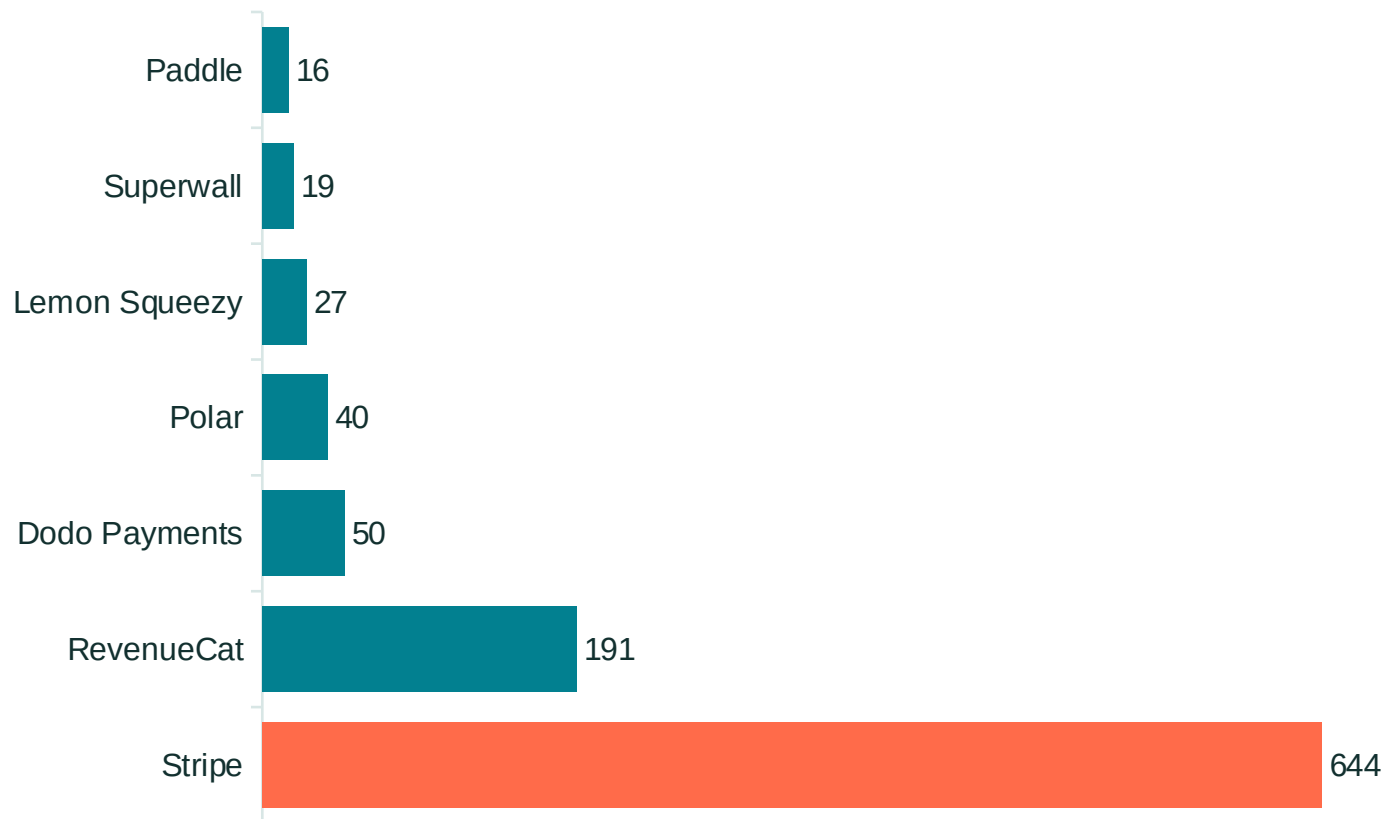
of startups made under \$100 in the last 30 days

26%

made over \$5,000 — almost as many as those making nothing

It's not a smooth long tail — it's a barbell. Startups cluster at \$0 and at \$5k+, with relatively few stuck in the middle.

How are founders collecting money?



64%

of startups run on Stripe

90%

of all revenue in the dataset flows through it

Stripe dominates on both count and dollars — ease of integration and global reach make it the default. RevenueCat is the clear #2, powering mobile subscription apps.

Which countries produce the most revenue?



Quantity ≠ quality.

India has 59 startups but ranks only 6th in revenue.

Singapore's 9 startups out-earn India's 59 in total revenue — nearly 10x more revenue per startup.

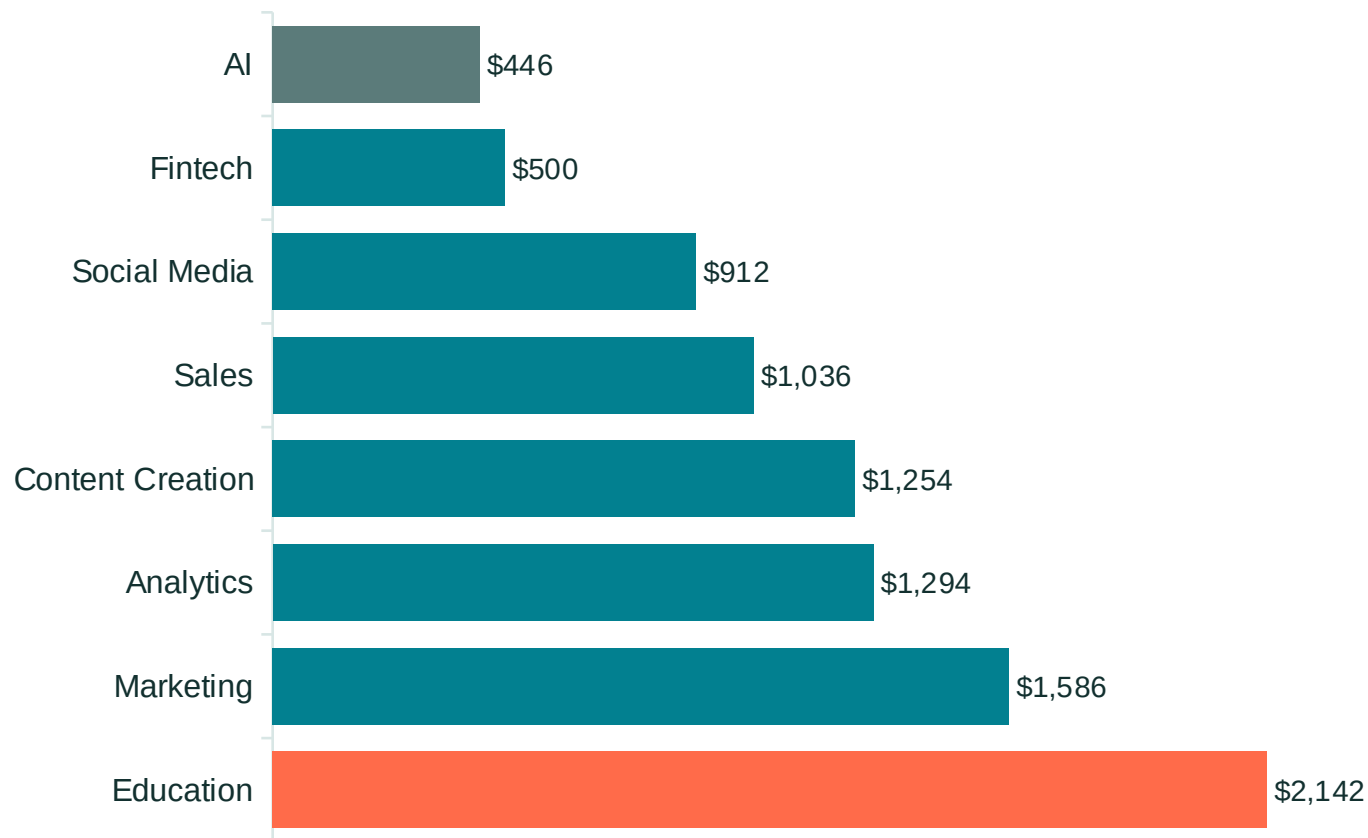
The most startups and the most revenue don't come from the same place. Founding volume and monetization success are two different games.

The highest-earning startups — what do they share?

#	Startup	Country	Category	12-mo Revenue
1	Stan	US	Unclassified	\$25,017,876
2	Brand On Demand, Inc.	US	E-comm	\$10,641,368
3	Stack Influence	US	Marketing	\$10,520,739
4	Stealth Company	Unknown	Unclassified	\$4,916,956
5	Comp AI	US	AI	\$3,938,680
6	1Lookup	US	SaaS	\$3,124,006
7	Rezi	US	AI	\$2,977,192
8	Stealth Company	GB	Unclassified	\$2,350,329
9	Cometly	US	Analytics	\$2,336,596
10	Kibu	US	Education	\$1,850,739

Every single top-10 earner runs on Stripe, and 9 of 10 are US-based — but their categories span creator tools, e-commerce, AI and marketing. There's no one winning niche, but there is a winning payment rail and a winning market.

MRR analysis: medians tell a different story



AI has 197 startups

— the most of any category, and the highest total revenue —

but a median MRR of just \$446.

Education (30 startups)

has a median MRR nearly 5x higher, at \$2,141.

AI's total revenue is propped up by a handful of huge outliers — the typical AI startup earns less than the typical Education or Marketing one.

Does a big following mean more revenue?

$$r \approx 0.02$$

the raw correlation between followers and revenue

Even on a log scale, the relationship stays weak ($r \approx 0.35$). A large audience is not a reliable predictor of revenue.

Plenty of low-follower startups out-earn high-follower ones. Distribution and audience help, but they don't substitute for a product people pay for.

The biggest surprises in the data

90%

of all revenue flows through Stripe alone — even though only 64% of startups use it.

38%

of startups earned under \$100 in the last 30 days, yet 26% earned over \$5,000 — almost no middle ground.

9 vs 59

Singapore's 9 startups collectively out-earn India's 59 — the country with more startups isn't the one with more revenue.

Key insights & what founders should do about it

KEY INSIGHTS

- 1 SaaS founding is globalizing — but revenue is still US-concentrated.
- 2 AI wins on volume and total revenue, not on typical (median) outcomes.
- 3 Payment rails matter: Stripe-backed startups dominate earnings.
- 4 Audience size is a weak predictor of revenue.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- 1 Judge markets by median MRR, not category hype — Education & Marketing show healthier unit economics than AI.
- 2 Default to mainstream payment infrastructure (Stripe) for credibility and conversion.
- 3 Build a revenue moat, not just a following — monetize deliberately, don't wait for audience size.
- 4 Look beyond the home market — global founders are competitive but need sharper monetization.